

Act Naturally

If only we could actually do that with computers!

Robert Sovereign-Smith

So many of us have already spent years, in terms of man-hours, sitting in front of a computer, clickity-clacking away at the keyboard, clicking a mouse and damaging tissue in our collective quest to develop the geek's disease—Carpal Tunnel Syndrome.

Think of how much the world of IT has changed: phones have gone from big bulky things that sat on your desk and weighed as much as a bowling ball to tiny little gadgets that fit into the pockets of a pair of skin-tight jeans; CPUs have gone from glorified calculators to teraflop-measured powerhouses; RAM and hard drives have gone from being measured in MBs to GBs today—not to mention having become several orders of magnitudes faster. Yet, sadly, the way we interface with our computers has remained unchanged...

The Mouse And Keyboard

This writer is plodding away at his keyboard writing this, and all of you do the same while using your computers. If you're not a keyboard warrior, you're most definitely a mouse wrestler. Ever since the GUI (graphical user interface) first

appeared, the mouse and keyboard have been a staple of our digital diets.

Sure, the mice and keyboards being made today are anything but ordinary (see box *Devices Of Desire*), but the fact of the matter is that this is just design, and not anything groundbreaking.

Other Controllers

The first major shift in input devices was brought about by gaming—so many of us grew up playing games on our Atari and Nintendo gaming systems. Next we saw joysticks being connected to computers; then there were the wheel controllers for car racing games.

However, we've seen gaming branch off into the direction of consoles, and they seem to have taken the controllers with them: who really uses a joystick or wheel on a PC anyway? It's so much simpler—not to forget cheaper—to just use the default interface devices, the trusty keyboard and mouse, for gaming.

Perhaps the truth is that we just haven't found anything better than these relics of technology to control our PCs. Well, hopefully, that's about to change. Perhaps not as soon as we might wish, but it'll change nonetheless.

Amidst all the hype over all the other thousands of new technologies and inventions that

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